

Use of Open Source Software for Web-Based Subject Guides in an Academic Library

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Abstract

Digital Literacy is the ability to use information and communication technologies to find, evaluate, create, and communicate information, requiring both cognitive and technical skills. Improving digital literacy skills is seen as a key goal by many libraries. Digital literacy builds on general literacy and reading skills to provide people with an understanding of how digital technology functions and how to use it effectively. Subjects plus is a web-based content management system designed specifically for libraries. This Subjects plus software facilitates the creation and management of subject guides, research guides, and course-specific guides, making it an invaluable tool for libraries seeking to enhance digital literacy among their patrons. This papers expounds the benefits of Subjects Plus at the Bishop Heber college library for creation of web based subjects guides and concludes with recommendation for further studies in this subject area.

Keywords: Open Source, Subjects plus, Subject Guide, Research Guide.

Introduction

In the information age dominated by digital devices, the concept of literacy has expanded beyond traditional reading and writing to include a new set of abilities and skills called digital literacy. Digital literacy is very important in today's information age, as the access to information is predominantly mediated via digital channels. As digital technology becomes more accessible, affordable, and portable, people from all backgrounds are increasing their online participation. Digital literacy is the technical and cognitive skills to process information in various formats, can use different technologies effectively, utilizes digital features to collaborate with others. As technology continues to evolve, digital literacy becomes increasingly important for individuals to thrive in both academic and professional settings.

Review of Literature

Manu and Nabi Hassan study found that use of Subjects Plus provide opportunities for library patrons to connect with library resources at their convenient time. It helps the library staff to understand the needs of scholars and develop content according to the their information needs (Manu & Hasan, 2023). In Blackburn's exploration of Subjects Plus, he discovered its remarkable capability to effectively manage a spectrum of online library resources. Notably, it excels in handling course-specific and miscellaneous topic guides, the library staff directory, and database links. Use of libguides saves the time of library for content creation and location of needed resources (Daws, 2016).

The impact of Subjects Plus extends beyond mere efficiency; it emerges as a significant time-saver. Selection of Subjects Plus for libguides helped them find their more discoverable among students (Blackburn & Walker, 2010). Bernier while discussing various benefits of libguides for library, he pointed out that the need for revision of web presence to integrate library resources with users to be relevant and be an user centric library (Bernier, 2010).

What is subject guides?

Subject Guides provide list of resources available electronically in the library on various subjects.. Preparation and deployment of such subject guides enhances the use of library resources. It requires careful planning and listing of topics on subjects fields and resources associated with these accessible through the library (Bhavsar, 2018) . subject guides offer help to scholars in locating credible resources on topic of their choice.

Digital Literacy

Digital literacy is the abilities to access the digital infrastructure. It is an understanding of the language and component hardware and software required to navigate the technology. In today's information age, digital literacy is no longer a luxury; it is a necessity. Individuals must be able to navigate online platforms, critically evaluate digital information, and interact responsibly with technology.

Subjects Plus

Subjects Plus is an open-source web based content management software specially used for the libraries. Subjects Plus was originally developed at the Ithaca College Library, and the development process is now taken place at the University of Miami Libraries. It is made available under the GNU General Public License. It is used for the Digital literacy purpose and to guide the user or researchers to find the information they need.

Benefits of Subjects Plus

Centralized Resource Management

Books, journals, databases, and other digital materials are just a few of the resources that may be managed centrally using Subjects Plus. The structure of materials is streamlined by this centralization, which facilitates access to and use of the vast amount of information for users and librarians alike.

User-Friendly Interface

Both library employees and users can navigate the software more easily thanks to its user-friendly interface. Subjects Plus's user-friendly design makes it simple to retrieve information, which enhances user satisfaction and motivates users to use library resources more frequently.

Customization for Institutional Needs

Subjects Plus's great degree of customization enables libraries to modify the platform to suit the unique requirements and tastes of their particular establishment. Because of this adaptability, libraries can design a special, customized setting that fits both their user needs and academic focus.

Effective Subject Guides

The program is particularly good at creating subject guides, which are helpful resources for pointing users in the direction of pertinent materials within a certain field of study. These manuals facilitate research procedures, improve information literacy, and provide users the tools they need to fully utilize the resources available in the library.

Collaborative Features

By enabling the sharing of resources and information, Subjects Plus encourages cooperation among library staff. Collaboratively, librarians may produce and update subject guides, exchange best practices, and guarantee that users have easy access to the most recent and pertinent materials.

Seamless Integration with Other Library Systems

Subjects Plus is made to work in unison with other library systems, including tools for discovery and cataloging. This integration makes sure that the library ecosystem is connected and unified, which facilitates effective data sharing and enhances user experience overall.

Support for Information Literacy

The software contributes significantly to information literacy initiatives by providing tools and resources that help users develop essential research skills. Subject guides and instructional materials created with Subjects Plus aid in guiding users through the research process and promoting a deeper understanding of information resources.

Responsive Design for Accessibility

Because Subjects Plus uses responsive design, it is accessible on a range of devices. With the help of this tool, users can more easily access library materials from desktops, laptops, tablets, and cellphones.

System Requirements

Subjects Plus runs under the XAMPP environment. X stands for Windows or Linux, A stands for the Apache web server, M stands for MySQL, and P stands for PHP. The easiest way to ensure all of these components are present is to download and install Wamp server. You should not need to know the following, but are listed for information only, the particular versions of these components that are required are described below:

1. Apache
2. MySQL 4+
3. PHP 5.2+

In addition to WAMP server, Javascript should be enabled for the Subjects Plus Admin interface to work properly.

Features of Subjects Plus

Subjects Plus is a LAMP/WAMP application that allows you to manage a number of interrelated parts of a library website:

1. Research Guides (i.e., subject, course, etc.)
2. Database A-Z List
3. Staff List
4. FAQs
5. Suggestion Box
6. Videos (i.e., produced in-library)
7. Installer/Updater
8. Multilingual
9. API
10. Customizable

Benefits of Subjects Plus in library

Use of Subjects Plus software provides various benefits such as;

Free and Open Source Software (FOSS)

Subjects Plus being free and open-source software means that libraries can use it without incurring licensing costs. Additionally, being open-source allows libraries to customize and modify the software to suit their specific needs, fostering adaptability.

Community Support

Subjects Plus benefits from a community of users and developers who contribute to its improvement and share knowledge. This community support ensures that libraries using Subjects Plus have access to a wealth of resources, including forums, documentation, and updates, enhancing the overall user experience.

Easy Admin Interface

The platform's user-friendly administrative interface simplifies the management of library resources and services. This ease of use is particularly beneficial for library staff, as it reduces the learning curve and streamlines the process of updating and maintaining information.

Easy to Create a Guide

Subjects Plus facilitates the creation of guides, making it a valuable tool for libraries to organize and present information effectively. Librarians can easily develop guides that assist users in navigating resources, finding relevant information, and optimizing their research experience.

Easy Way to Literate the Library Users

The platform's features support educational initiatives by providing an accessible way to impart information literacy skills to library users. Librarians can utilize Subjects Plus to create tutorials, guides, and other instructional materials, promoting a more literate and informed user base.

Easy Access

Subjects Plus ensures easy access to library resources by providing a centralized platform for information. Users can quickly locate and access relevant materials, reducing the time spent searching for resources and enhancing the overall efficiency of the library services.

Challenges of Subjects Plus

1. Function of database is a little bit slow
2. Only one admin can use it at a time

Technical support

In Subjects Guide software there is a Google Group community, which will help us to encounter the problem in case. Also there is some YouTube video also available in the help section to clarify our doubts.

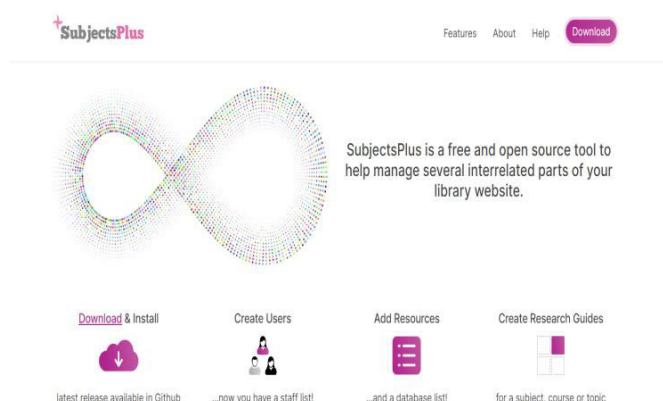


Fig.1 Subjects Plus Software (<https://subjectsplus.github.io/>)

Fig.1 shows the availability of subjectsplus for download (SubjectsPlus, 2024) and installation.

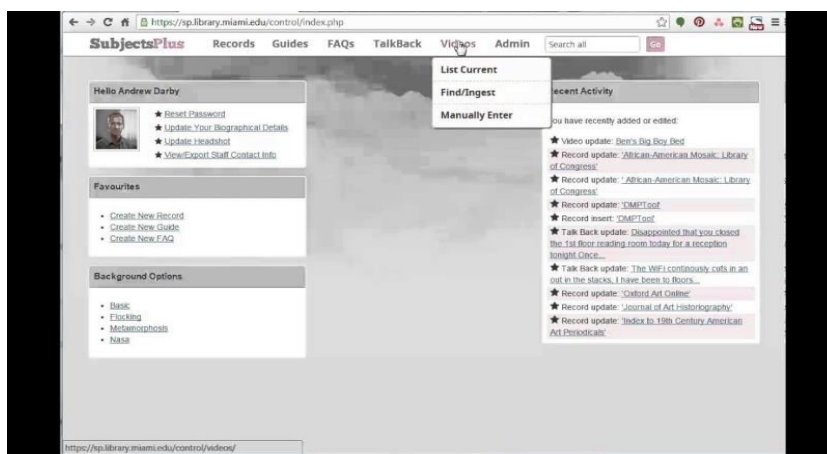


Fig.2 Subjects Plus Interface

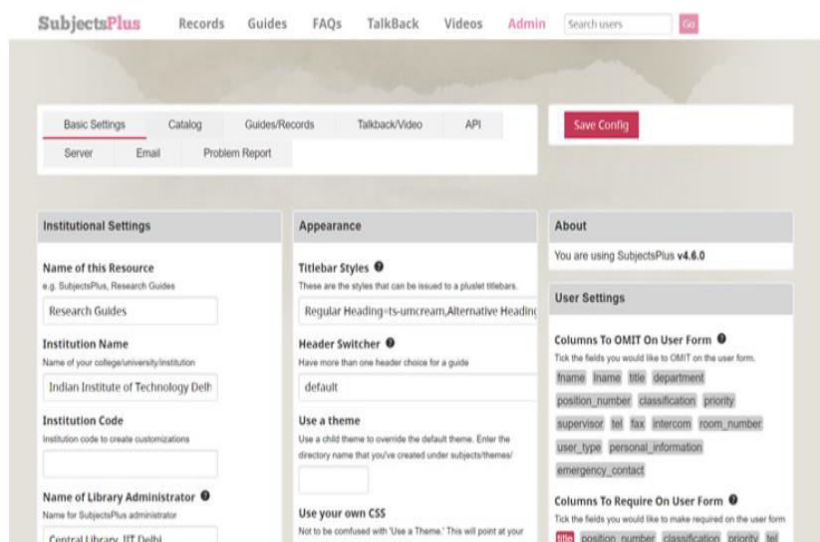


Fig.3 Subject plus configuration

Fig.3 shows the configuration of Subjects Plus to carry out administrative tasks. In this stage library staff will have to clearly specify the categories of subjects, guides and other useful tools for the benefit of library users.

Bishop Heber College

Bishop Heber College, an Autonomous institution affiliated with Bharathidasan University, Trichirappalli has successfully completed 57 years of academic endeavour by providing quality higher education that places a strong emphasis on Holistic Development. The College offers UG, PG, and Ph.D programmes under Aided and Self-Financed Sections without compromising the quality. The bishop Heber College is Nationally Re-accredited at the 'A++' by NAAC with a CGPA of 3.69 in September 2023 (Bishop Heber College, 2024).

BHC Library

The Bishop Heber College Library serves as a catalyst, facilitating the user community's scholarly exploration, learning endeavours, and the generation of novel ideas. Its wealth of robust information resources dedicated to teaching, learning and research plays a pivotal role in connecting individuals with intellectual growth and innovative pursuits. Library collection includes physical and electronic resources. The subscribed electronic resources can be accessed from on and off campus. The Library is fully automated using KOHA Open Source Library Management Software integrated with RFID technology, Self-Service Kiosk & Web OPAC.

Electronic Resources

Through eSodh Sindhu consortium and NList, BHC library users have access to over 6000 e-journals and 1.99 lakh e-books. Subject lists for these resources will enhance the usage of resources by the patrons. In addition to the above, departmental repositories and open access resources are also included in the library information portal. In this context deployment of web based tool like Subjects Plus becomes handy for library users to locate and access resources and be able to interact with library staff team in case of further information needs.

Implementation of Subjects Plus

The Bishop Heber College Library finds that SubjectsPlus software is an invaluable resource, especially when it comes to organizing the many databases that are accessible. With the wide variety of databases available to support different academic fields, the program makes subject guide creation easier and provides librarians with a useful tool. SubjectsPlus centralized database management features let librarian at Bishop Heber College Library arrange, classify, and display database content in an understandable way. Librarian may effortlessly explore and amend details in the subject guides because to their user-friendly interface, which guarantees that the guides are up to date and accurate representations of the wide range of resources available. By the use of the software's customization tools, subject guides may be made to specifically fit the requirements of Bishop Heber College Library, giving teachers and students access to carefully chosen material that is pertinent to their academic goals. All things considered, SubjectsPlus makes it easier to create subject guides for the many databases in the Library, improving accessibility and usefulness for the Bishop Heber College Library users.

BHC Library already has advanced technology and a wide selection of electronic resources. So the implementation of SubjectsPlus software is a strategic requirement in order to further improve its products and guarantee ongoing growth. Since SubjectsPlus is an open-source platform, it works very well with the library's mission to become innovative and efficient. Using the SubjectsPlus, the library can enhance its current electronic resources by adding personalized guides, tutorials, and educational materials, which promote a engaging the learning experience.

Subjects plus Implementation Stages

Below listed steps are followed for implementation of Subjects Plus.

1. *Selection:* In this stage identification of resources on various discipline / subjects is carried out. In this process library staff would list the resources available in both print and electronic resources.
2. *Collection:* In collection stage, resources are gathered and listed according to the disciplines and topics. Use of standard subjects headings would be invaluable for library users. Important research tools, reference management tools, open access repositories and other useful tutorials are included.

3. *Evaluation*: In this stage the collected resources are reviewed and carefully evaluated for suitability and their currency.
4. *Organize*: After having reviewed and evaluated, the resources are organised systematically.
5. *Populate*: Relevant records for the above resources are populated in subjectsplus.

Conclusion

SubjectsPlus software significantly enhances overall functioning and user experience if integrated into a library website. SubjectsPlus gives librarians the ability to construct dynamic and customized subject guides by providing a unified platform for resource administration, easy navigation, and extensive customization possibilities. Because of its collaborative capabilities, library staff members work together to keep the guides up to date and useful. An effective and cohesive library environment is further enhanced by the software's responsiveness and smooth integration with other library systems. In the end, SubjectsPlus demonstrates its versatility and indispensability as a tool for libraries, helping them better arrange, display, and make resources more easily accessible on their websites. This improves the overall level of assistance and service that libraries offer to their users.

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